

library of patchouli - thread

The Spider's Thread

by Ryūnosuke Akutagawa

6/10

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this is an even shorter one than hell screen. i read the gist of this short story from the garden of evening mists, where arimoto references the story, maybe to parallel his own plight. i think kandas actions seemed reasonable enough for one immersed in hell's blood pond like him: he wanted to climb onto the thread alone and ascend into the heavens for himself only.

and hence he shouted to those below to sod off.

i think the act of selflessness in buddhism is really respectful. they strive not to excel and become gods themselves, but to 普渡众生 (lit. save them all). i think what i take away from this is the spirit of not taking away from others, but rather guiding them to the light if i myself have a way to it.

this story does not shake me as strongly as the others so i will not give it a very high score. i think it is somewhat sad though. 6/10

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> If only he could take hold of this thread and climb up and up, he could probably escape from Hell. And maybe, with luck, he could even enter Paradise. Then he would never again be driven up the Mountain of Needles or plunged down into the Pond of Blood.

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> Kandata screamed at them, 'Listen to me, you sinners! This spider thread is mine! Who said you could climb it? Get off! Get off!'

At that very instant the spider thread, which until then had been perfectly fine, broke with a 'snap!' just where Kandata was hanging from it. Before he could even cry out, Kandata fell, slicing through the air, spinning like a top, down head-first into the darkest depths.

Behind him all that remained was the dangling short end of the spider thread from Paradise, delicately gleaming in the moonless, starless sky.